

Mini miracle: (Facing page) The tiny Caribbean island of Curacao became the least populous nation ever to qualify for the World Cup. AFP

It secured a place in the inter-confederation play-off for 2026 by beating African heavyweight Nigeria on penalties and could complete its redemption arc should it defeat New Caledonia or Suriname in the play-off final.

"These are proud moments for football in Africa. The main objective is for an African nation to win the World Cup," Patrice Motsepe, president of the Confederation of African Football, previously said.

"We are absolutely confident that the performance at the World Cup will serve as a significant stimulus and accelerator for the very good work taking place in increasing the quality and global competitiveness of African football."

Asia — an underrated chapter

Asia has been another overlooked presence in the World Cup, appearing in the knockouts just twice, with its best-ever performance — South Korea reaching the 2002 semifinals — becoming a footnote rather than a headline.

But the expansion has created room for success stories that would have otherwise slipped through the cracks of history.

Uzbekistan, which played its first international match post-independence in 1992, became the first Central Asian nation to qualify for the World Cup.

Meanwhile, Jordan, which had not even qualified for the Asian Cup until 2004, completed a dream run to the 2026 World Cup, beating Oman 3-0.

Beyond the usual suspects of Japan, Iran and South Korea, Qatar qualified on merit for the first time, while Iraq is one step away from its first World Cup appearance since 1986.

There are other success stories in the 2026 edition. The tiny Caribbean island of Curacao became the least populous nation ever to qualify for the



World Cup. Haiti, infamous for gang violence, also made the tournament without playing a single qualifier on home soil.

The broader picture

The allure of playing at a World Cup also provides players with a chance to represent their native countries, which would otherwise not be possible with a smaller pool.

Axel Tuanzebe, a former England Under-21 international who has also captained Manchester United, failed to break into the Three Lions' senior squad. He eventually switched allegiance to DR Congo, his birth country, in 2023.

So did his United teammate Aaron Wan-Bissaka, who was also born to

Historic debut: Uzbekistan, which played its first international match post independence in 1992, became the first Central Asian nation to qualify for the showpiece tournament. AFP

Congolese parents. Congo is on the brink of making it to the finals.

Mason Greenwood — once touted as one of England's best youth talents — switched to Jamaica after falling out of Thomas Tuchel's plans.

Giant leap: Fans of Cape Verde celebrate its World Cup qualification. The country will make its debut as the third-least populous nation and the second-smallest by land area. AFP

